

38 Speculation and deduction

You can use modal verbs to describe past events with varying degrees of certainty. These constructions are useful for speculating about events you haven't witnessed.

-  **New language** More uses for modal verbs
- Aa Vocabulary** Phrasal verbs with "out"
-  **New skill** Speculating and making deductions

38.1 KEY LANGUAGE MODAL VERBS FOR SPECULATION AND DEDUCTION

When you're speculating about the past and you're sure something happened, use "must have" with the past participle.

He just disappeared. Aliens **must have abducted** him.

The speaker is sure.



When you're not sure whether something happened or not, replace "must" with "may," "might," or "could."

They **might may could** **have taken** him to another planet.

The speaker is unsure.



If you are sure something did not happen, use "can't" or "couldn't."

Hold on! It **can't couldn't** **have been** aliens, they don't exist.

The speaker is sure it is not possible.



38.2 MATCH THE PAIRS OF SENTENCES TOGETHER

He drove his car into the water!

1

He's walking with crutches.

2

Those teenagers look very tired today.

3

The plants are all dry and dead.

4

Someone's left the gate open again.

5

The girl next door looks really happy.

He must have hurt his legs.

It could have been the delivery man.

They may have had a party last night.

He couldn't have seen the "flood" sign.

She might have passed her exam.

It can't have rained all week.

